



Shadow of the past: Despite showing shades of his prime in recent fights, Jose Aldo's (left) latest duel against a surging Mario Bautista showed that he was outclassed.

competitive back-and-forth battle that went the distance (**below**).

Peña returned to the octagon after a two-year hiatus but never looked out of shape as she secured a split-decision win over her compatriot. Peña started strong, outstriking Pennington in the first round and then controlling her for the second and third rounds. However, Peña began to slow down, getting dropped in the fourth round and dominated in the fifth. When the final bell rang, many believed Pennington had won rounds one, four, and five, but in the end, it was Peña who won via split decision.

"I wasn't sure," Peña responded when asked if she thought she had done enough to earn the victory. "I heard these judges tonight were doing some crazy stuff. Unfortunately, I went to a decision. Just a loss of focus, and that's what I would say — I got dropped. Need to be a little bit more focused."

Not an ideal swansong

The final chapter of José Aldo's UFC career has been a shaky affair. In

2022, a crushing loss at the hands of Merab Dvalishvili pushed him to the brink of retirement.

But earlier this year, Aldo returned from a brief retirement in May with a masterful decision win over Jonathan Martinez in Rio de Janeiro. It was a vintage Aldo performance, as the former featherweight champion looked sharp and focused, immediately putting Martinez on the back foot and never allowing him to build any momentum.

Although one could see shades of prime Aldo, his latest fight against the surging Mario Bautista showed that he was outclassed.

Bautista displayed a diverse range of attacks and maintained composure against 'Junior'. The 31-year-old's most rewarding moves came along the edges of the cage, where he repeatedly pushed and pinned Aldo.

Though Aldo had some very good moments, especially in the second round, Bautista's constant activity, relentless pressure, and the grinding nature of his fighting style proved too much.

Two of the three judges scored the fight in favour of the Arizona-based bantamweight, who continues to demonstrate that he is a rising name in the bantamweight division.

